

Snow Melts on My Boots

Åsmund Kværnstrøm

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People shouldn't wander around. Well-adjusted people don't wander around. When they're out walking, they have a purpose.

The snow crunches under my feet. I step where no one else has. Jump from side to side to hear the light, fresh snow compress beneath my soles. So many cars and people. But no voices.

Outside a KIWI supermarket, I stamp the snow off my boots and brush down my jacket.

I go inside to warm my nose and ears.

Freezers. Special offers. A few cartons of eggs.

By the checkout, a basket of discounted milk chocolate and Twix.

Five kroner for the chocolate.

Eleven for a Twix.

I take three of each.

The girl at the checkout greets every customer. Then she lowers her eyes and works quickly. She looks sad and cowed. Could it have something to do with the scar on her right cheek?

She tries to hide it.

I'm standing in a puddle of dirty water and sand.

My turn.

I make an effort to greet her pleasantly. Don't want to add to her burden. She glances at me before focusing on the chocolate. Runs the bars over the scanner. Beep.

The numbers flash on the checkout display.

I tap my card and have a feeling the total is wrong.

I say goodbye. She whispers back, nods, and looks at me but doesn't quite meet my gaze.

Next customer.

Outside, with flakes of snow falling, I do the maths. I definitely paid too much. But it's small change, so why complain? I've never complained. Why start now? On the bus, I sit with the beanie and mittens Grandma knitted in my lap. There's snow on them, and it's melting.

The supermarket played me. It played us.

I should have been one of those pleasant customers who spoke up while praising the girl for being helpful and accommodating. She would have forgotten her sadness while we sorted it out.

Two others get off the bus before me.
I pull on my beanie and mittens.
The doors slam shut and the bus whines away.

The satisfying crunch of snow under my feet.
The others leave tracks. I step around their tracks.
Snow settles on the toes of my boots and clings
to the laces.
I try to look up and ahead.

People must notice that I'm always looking down.

Is that why we're on nodding terms, nothing more?

A group appears. I recognise most of them.
They're the ones who occupy the TV room.

All that noise because they missed the bus.

When the Champions League is on, they squeeze
themselves onto the sofa even when someone
else is already sitting there.

When I'm standing outside the front door, it's as
if the dorm has closed its eyes and gone to sleep.
I let myself in and hear muffled sounds from the
TV room. A couple is sitting on the sofa with
their arms around each other in the glow of a film.
They don't notice me pass.

A door opens upstairs and I listen for the direction of the footsteps.

Silence.

No rumble of washing machines.

In my room, I go to bed even though I don't want to sleep and probably won't be able to.

The KIWI girl keeps me awake all night. I get a couple of hours' sleep in the morning. The solution is there when I open my eyes. I need to be at the supermarket before two to catch the first shift. If that's not when she finishes, it's probably when she starts.

It's never busy at that time, is it?

They have a postal counter.

I take my phone from the inside pocket of my jacket. The screen is damp, and I have missed calls and messages.

The Posten app shows how busy the collection point is when you've ordered a parcel. I could just order something cheap.

A digital Casio watch.

Keyboard.

Mouse.

Then I can have it delivered to KIWI.

That's plan B.

I eat oats with milk and strawberry jam.

My boots are still damp from yesterday, so I scrunch up some toilet paper and stuff it into the toes.

Outside the window, the beech trees sway in the wind.

I hear the bathroom door and feet slap against the floor in the hallway. Out of habit, I spring from the kitchen, throw myself across the hall and slip into the bathroom. The lino is covered in water and my socks get wet even though I stand with my legs apart.

After changing my socks, I sit at the computer and put on my headphones. RulerOfAll8 wants me to join the game. Slayer506X joins us.

We all get killed. Every time.

— What are you doing, IronSaber! Are you sick?! (Slayer506X)

— Off my game, sorry!

DC, I type, and log off.

I search for a thought that might calm me down.

There's that PC upgrade I've been thinking about.

I browse chipsets, find one and order it.

The unease comes back.

On the way to the bus stop, I bury my nose in my scarf.

I remember that I've decided to walk differently, so I straighten my back. With only my eyes showing, I lift my head and look ahead.

She's not at KIWI at quarter to two.

On the patch of bare asphalt outside the supermarket, I buy a magazine for fifty kroner from a street seller.

My fingers are too cold to turn the pages.

I go back and ask if I can sit beside him.

He smiles and nods.

His eyes narrow when I sit down.

My ass is freezing and I lose feeling in my toes.

— I'm impressed you can sit here all day,
I say.

He looks at me darkly. When a couple walks past,
he turns and smiles.

— Hi, he says, smiling as he holds out the
magazine.

— Not today, they say without looking at
him.

A draft carries a sweet, unpleasant smell from the
rubbish bins by the supermarket entrance. I
shiver and have just struggled to my feet when a
young couple walks over. The woman holds out a
fifty-kroner note.

— Thank you.

— You deserve it, she says.

— But I'm not him—he's the one who
needs the money, I say, pointing at the man with
the magazines and realizing I don't know his
name.

— Just take it and get yourself a cup of
coffee.

They smile sympathetically as they hurry into the store.

The magazine seller pushes me. Not hard, just enough to make me understand that this isn't OK.

— OK.

I raise my arms in what I hope is a disarming gesture.

Before I know it, he's snatched the fifty-kroner note from my fingers.

— Take it easy. I was going to give it to you, I say.

The seller takes a step towards me.

I brace myself.

I refuse to meet his eyes and point at the door.

— I've got something to do in there, I say. It's two o'clock.

At least this isn't wandering around.

I go through the automatic doors and walk past the fruit and vegetables.

She's nowhere to be seen.

Maybe she's in the stockroom. I could ask for her, but they'd think I was crazy.

I sweep through the store again.

Still no sign of her. I buy more discounted chocolate along with three Red Bulls and three Cokes. It all fits in my backpack.

Outside again.

That was stupid. I hadn't even planned what words to use if I saw her.

Probably just as well she wasn't there.

The cold works its way under my jacket and trousers.

The magazine seller watches me.

I take the bus home. Every time it stops, cold air rushes in and I don't get warm until I'm home and have downed two cups of coffee.

It's not her fault, poor thing.

The next day, I make three bus trips. Getting the most out of my monthly pass.

The chocolate piles up in my backpack.

After the last visit, I pour the bars onto the ground beside the magazine seller.

— A peace offering, I say, hoping he can hear the gentleness in my voice.

He's ignored me all day. Now he looks at me suspiciously, but stuffs the chocolate into his pockets.

I check the receipt from my last purchase. The total is correct.

Vindication costs more than the loss. I accept that.

When I go to bed, my legs and back ache.

It'll be nice to lie in tomorrow.

It's Friday.

I wake to the sound of water and sewage trickling through the pipes from the floor above. Half asleep, I imagine installing the chipset. My body aches, and I stay in bed and watch YouTube until my stomach rumbles.

After a bowl of oats, I manage to get into the bathroom without anyone noticing. When I pull my knitted sweater over my head, I get stuck and try again.

Tomorrow is Saturday and there'll be lots of people at the store. Too many. I decide to take the bus. Give myself a chance today.

Another message on my phone. I don't want to look at it, but I force myself. It's from my sister. Two missed calls and ten messages. I glance at the last one:

Where are you? We're worried. You weren't on the train—you need to let us know you're OK!

The magazine seller is gone.

Her tilted head.

Behind two sets of automatic doors, she's trying to hide the scar as she serves a customer. Now that I've learned to keep my head up, I'm going to teach her. The doors press against my shoulders and I hurry inside.

I grab a green shopping basket and make my way to the refrigerated section for a litre of low-fat milk.

On the way to the checkout, I pick up a bag of oats.

She looks exactly the same.

No queue.

She says hello and picks up the carton of milk.

Scans it.

— It's not your fault, you know, I say.

She watches me with her head tilted, and I wish she wouldn't hide the scar. I'm trying to be friendly. To let her know I don't blame her.

She scans the bag of oats.

I search her face for gratitude.

— What do you mean? she says.

There's a crease between her eyebrows.

I hate it when people are angry. Can she be angry when her voice is that quiet?

— It's not your fault I paid too much last time. I just wanted you to know.

The words I planned disappear.

Like that time I stood on the ten-metre diving platform and everything started spinning. All I could see was turquoise water before I threw up. I'm not who I planned to be. My stomach twists.

I can't speak.

IronSaber, where are you?

I run towards the bus stop. The carton of milk and the bag of oats in my hands. I can't remember whether I paid for them. My breath comes in bursts.

When I stop, my jacket is open. My mittens are still in the store.

I thought if I could talk to her, I'd be calm again.

Have a future.

Will I ever pick up that chipset?

My sister knows my exams are over.

I could text her I drank too much yesterday.

That I missed the train because I had to sleep it off.

Unlikely.

The other excuse I could send her is:

Girl trouble.

Completely ridiculous.

But true.

It's the strangest combination of words I've ever considered writing to my sister.

To anyone.

I try to type them, but my fingers won't obey. Not even autocorrect can manage it. If I take another day to think about it, they'll probably report me missing. Not my parents. They haven't called. But my sister.

There must be a pen somewhere.

At the bottom of my backpack. My maths book comes out with it.

G I R L, I write on the back of an envelope from the student loan office.

The resistance gets stronger.

TROUBL

One letter left.

I use my left hand to help push it out: E.

There.

I write it again. This time I manage with my right hand alone. Again, a little faster. Then faster still, until the word has become part of my hand's vocabulary. Almost as easy to write as Coke, coffee, assignment or exam. I type it into my phone:

Girl trouble.

My sister replies immediately:

Didn't see that coming! :-D But when are you coming?

I suppose that means she's happy for me.

Have to sort out the girl trouble first. Sorry I missed the train.

Tell me more when I see you. Good luck with the girl. Go for it!

Girl trouble.

That's good.

I'm not wandering around.

For the next few days, I have the bathroom to myself. The hallways are quiet. There is only the occasional trickling sound from the pipes.

During the days, I program and game.

One night I dream that she doesn't recognise me and I wake up with disappointment piercing my stomach. Another night, I dream that she rests her eyes on me and says *hello again*. I freeze and the feeling sticks. It lingers throughout the day.

This is Catch 22.

Night or day, they feel the same.

My telephone beeps with a message about my package and the collection code.

All I can do is what I have planned: *Sorry about last time*. Get the package. Done.

The busdriver stares.

– Are you OK?

– No worries.

I sit and he eventually stops looking at me in his rearview mirror.

I pull Grandma's mittens and beanie on. From the bus stop, I see that the magazine seller is gone.

The rubbish bins send their smell in my direction as I get closer. I find the collection code and walk in.

When she glances at me from behind the checkout, I see recognition.

She gets up and disappears behind a concrete pillar.

When she re-appears, she looks at me.

— Sorry about last time, I say.

That's all I planned to say. Fewer words mean fewer words that can go wrong.

She looks at me with her head tilted, trying to hide the scar.

— You probably don't remember me, I say.

Hoping.

— How could I forget? she says.

I hope she's smiling. I think she's smiling.

— Sorry again. You looked sad that day.
Maybe you were having a bad day. Or maybe
you're having a bad month or a bad year.

I stop myself. The next logical thing to say is that
she's having a bad life.

— Thanks for caring, she says.

— I'm actually here to pick up a chipset.

— Upgrading the system, I see.

She says it without asking for ID or the collection
code.

— Got to upgrade the system, I say like
an idiot, my face getting hot.

— Do you game?

Now I can see that she's smiling. I turn around,
but there's no one behind me.

— Yeah, a little. Or ... Quite a lot,
actually.

She's holding my mittens.

— Henriette, she says, holding out her
other hand. Or Slayer506X.
Whatever you prefer.

Thank you for reading

Åsmund Kværnstrøm